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Aliserai 2: Destined Road

by Leopold Ambry

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Act One

The Arena

A group of four fighters arrives in a border town to challenge the new local champion in the arena. The chapter opens with a description of the group's actions and their conversation as they spend the day before the fight enjoying the town. It also describes the town, its surroundings, and the situation around it. On the evening of the second day they face the local champion — a massive brute who reportedly hasn't lost any of his three matches. The group, whose name is "Pitchfork" (since there are four of them), faces the champion. The fight is shown from their perspective, and they lose. After the fight, as they're dragged out of the arena following a one-sided beatdown, it's revealed that the champion was Hesiri.

The local magistrate and organizer of the games had promised her a travel permit that would let them continue on — the empire has recently closed all the roads, and Hesiri wouldn't be able to get a small girl past the checkpoints otherwise. The magistrate promises her one more fight, and if she wins, not only will he give her the permit, he'll pay her too. Hesiri mostly just knocks her opponents unconscious without serious injury, which annoys the crowd somewhat, but she refuses to hurt anyone too badly.

Meanwhile, Nara spends most of her time in the arena being looked after by the magistrate's son and daughter. Almost a month has passed since the massacre at the ball. Hesiri and Nara have been traveling for three weeks and have spent a week in this town before continuing on — not counting the week they spent in Iba'aresh right after the massacre. Hesiri learns that her final opponent will be a monster the magistrate bought specifically for the finale.

Hesiri and Nara spend some time together in the town, and then Hesiri faces the monster and defeats it. Unfortunately, doing so costs Hesiri the tattoo on her right wrist — its automatic poison effect is used up/destroyed for good in the fight.

We learn that Hesiri still sees Ladrien's ghost, and now talks with him much more often. Afterward, she and Nara prepare for the road; with the money from the arena, Hesiri buys a sword to replace the dagger she can no longer summon, and the two girls set off. She has enough money to choose a short silver sword, which she names Illya.

Meanwhile, the Inquisition arrives in the city; behind the scenes it threatens Kilorn with the terror of the Black Inquisitor, and it's revealed that the Aliserai are run by the Church, which is furious over their failure. While High Priest Shezmu decides on their punishment, we learn at the end that he'll send Safrek to find and kill Hesiri.

We also learn that Halfer unsuccessfully tried to free his daughter. Kilorn finds out and orders her entire left arm sent to Halfer as a threat, with a note reading: "A few more times and you'll have her back home in one piece." He then tells his servant, "Something along those lines — and make sure it sounds as insane as possible."

The Caravan

Hesiri and Nara bought horses in the last town and are learning to ride. Hesiri already has some experience, though limited. While riding along a road hemmed in by hills, a rockslide hits them. A rock falls directly on Nara, but it turns out Nara is a teleportation mage. She'd hidden this from Hesiri because her previous captors beat her when they found out she could do it. Hesiri is glad, though, and starts teaching Nara.

Toward the end, they run into a group of gnome merchants and join them as fellow travelers rather than as protection, since the gnomes see them as just two girls. (Note: nothing drastic happens to this caravan over the next several chapters — there will be a few skirmishes but no tragedy, so the story isn't uniformly grim throughout.)

Hesiri and Nara set out accompanied by the group of gnomes and one Taur. Within a few days they reach the point where the central province ends and an inhospitable wasteland begins. It almost never rains, the roads are not only unpaved but unmaintained, and the heat becomes unbearable. Hesiri, dressed in clothing that's thin but still fairly warm in order to cover her tattoos, doesn't handle it well, so the gnomes sell her clothing made of fabric that's thin yet sturdy enough for this kind of weather. They're actually traveling clear across the empire to sell their goods in Anubet, with their only protection being the Taur guard.

We learn a lot about the group of gnomes, and also about life outside the empire's center, somewhere neither Hesiri nor Nara have ever been. Hesiri also learns about the region to the south, the endless forests she's so far only heard about in passing.

During one of the skirmishes, Hesiri saves the group and thereby reveals herself as more than she seems. They don't judge her at all for the deception, though — they just thank her.

Act Two

Safrek's Trail

Safrek is already on the road and arrives in the arena town, where he tortures the local magistrate to death in front of his two children and learns where Hesiri was headed. His brutality and immense strength are shown here.

We also learn some of his backstory: Safrek didn't have a bad life — loving parents, wealth, a kind younger sister. But one day he hit his head falling into a well. From then on it was downhill; nothing in the world could cheer him up anymore. When he finally tried pushing his sister into a well so she'd understand his logic, she broke her neck on the way down. In that exact moment he understood what he actually enjoys in life. The Order bought him as a slave from the Chrosireth coal mine and turned him into an Aliserai.

The Long Road

Hesiri is now well-acquainted with the gnomes and the Taur, who trains her with the sword. They move into a more dangerous part of the empire, leading to more clashes.

In the end they part ways when their paths start leading in different directions, and the gnomes give Hesiri a farewell gift — an armband/vambrace made of nearly indestructible metal, on account of the ugly scar on that

wrist.

Act Three

Other Threads

Kilorn and Iba'aresh chapters, in which Kilorn defeats a Neferit so he can experiment on the eolith he extracts from it. The assault is difficult, and even with August's help they only manage to sever one of the golem's arms.

The Church catches up with Hesiri and Nara in a town, and the two go into hiding, already cooperating with each other more. Nara ends up saving Hesiri from a Church warrior when she finally manages to teleport someone along with herself. The Church holds a parade in the town, through which we learn more about its structure. Hesiri eventually fights one of them, a kemet enforcer (different and much weaker than a kemet inquisitor) — a mutant in a black bull mask. He's tall, superhumanly strong, fast, and resilient. He uses special weapons: three spikes that he drives into enemies, two of black metal and one of gold.

Another Safrek chapter shows him closing in on Hesiri. He passes through several locations Hesiri has been to, and talks to one of his victims, saying he simply can't help himself. He loves violence and holds no grudge against anyone who resents him for it. He expects mercy from no one, and doesn't think anyone should expect it from him either. He's stopped caring about the Order — he just wants Hesiri.

He doesn't believe in fate, yet he's currently heading straight toward an ancient oracle in pursuit of his prey. Maybe it's not just irony, but actual fate. Either way, he can't wait to find out which it is. Then he realizes the victim he was talking to is already dead. He leaves a postal station full of mutilated corpses and moves on. At the end of the chapter he sees the temple of Illyn Erai. (The corpses are only described once he gets up and starts to leave — until then, the reader only knows the victim's sex and that they're in front of him.)

The Oracle's Temple

Hesiri meets the oracle by breaking into the temple after being refused entry. The oracle explains that fate can't be changed, and that knowing it is itself a punishment. She tells Hesiri nothing at all, only advising that as long as she doesn't know her fate, it can still be anything.

Meanwhile, Safrek is waiting in the temple and murders one of the priestesses. Hesiri learns the priestess can't help her, because once you learn your future, there's no going back. Hesiri returns to Nara in the outer part of the temple, where Safrek is already waiting. He mocks her for wanting to know her fate: "Do you want to know your fate, Hesiri? Then let me tell you: you'll die. Not of old age in bed surrounded by friends and family, and not in some fight a few years from now — but now. Right here, right now, I'll finally kill you with these two hands."

He reveals to Hesiri that no one but her has the heart tattoo, and that this is deliberate — the tattoo takes years off her life every time she uses it; she was always meant to die young. After a bloody fight, desperation forces her to activate the heart tattoo, but Safrek underestimates her. Using the same gesture Tahar taught her, she deactivates the tattoo and crushes his skull with a single blow — her first kill in the six months since she left the capital. She knocks him to the ground and, in an explosion of rage, tears him apart with her bare hands, screaming and howling, asking why they simply won't leave her alone.

Wrecked and at the end of her strength, she decides that she and Nara will go back to Iba'aresh to take revenge on the Order. Hesiri, whose heart now seizes frequently, assumes she'll die the next time she uses that tattoo. During the final clash, Nara tries to teleport Hesiri away, but Hesiri instead has to save her, since Safrek immediately tries to crush the meddling girl.

The Church learns of Safrek's failure and threatens the Order with extermination. Tahar learns the Church plans to soon wipe out all the Aliserai and decides to flee once the attack begins — for now, he prepares. Kilorn continues his eolith experiments, learning more about it and how to strengthen and use it properly, or at least starts to figure it out. Amir also learns of the coming extermination and decides he'll prepare for that day and lead all the young Aliserai away. The extermination itself is meant to happen in Book 3.

Epilogue

Hesiri travels back and finally arrives back in the city.

Character Roster & Evolution (Whole Book)

Safrek Safrek wants to catch up with Hesiri because she reminds him of his sister. He wants to kill and torture, but the best part is the fight itself. In the moment of a clash, there is only Safrek and his opponent — no one else. He feels joy from suffering, and in a fight the two of them are focused only on each other; his opponent understands him, in that moment. His sister didn't survive the fall into the well, but Hesiri endures more. Much more. He'll also get smaller scenes of his pursuit outside his own solo chapters, but few and brief.

Nara Nara starts to see Hesiri as a mother figure. She doesn't mind when Hesiri decides to go back to the city — she wants to be with her, since Hesiri is the only one who neither leaves her nor hurts her. That attachment will at times border on unhealthy. Over the book she'll get better at using teleportation and will feel she's distanced herself from her past — or at least thinks so, until they return to the city. She'll get along very well with the gnomes, even better than Hesiri does. Her arc is the end of her fear that Hesiri will simply get up and leave her. She comes to realize she'll only lose Hesiri if Hesiri dies — which starts becoming a real possibility only in the second half of the book.

Hesiri Hesiri sees an unexpected shift in her view of the gnomes and starts to believe that it's specifically humans who are the source of hatred — even among people she's grown fond of. Her rule about not hurting people stays, but only applies to the good ones now. She continues to refuse to kill — until, of course, she kills Safrek. Even then, she treats it as a necessity. Ladrien's ghost speaks calmly and talks with her more often now without any aggression — more conversation than anything else, which Hesiri accepts. Around the end of chapter 30, though, he disappears completely. Along the road she'll train with the sword as a new fighting style, and will learn to combine it with her second, still-functioning tattoo on her left wrist.

The Caravan Five gnome merchants and one Taur guard with white fur. Smaller than the Taur Hesiri knew, but wise, kind, and skilled with a sword. He'll later train Hesiri. The gnomes are clever and also kind. Two of them are non-identical twins, and the rest are acquaintances of each other. Travelers from the southern forests.

Their names: Kever Leniš, Otto Leniš, Šalem Ekivelt, Prajca Deltán, Mips Avelon.

Scene Notes

First meeting with the caravan A green mark on the map, indicating the only oasis for miles around, turns out to be a food stain. In the actual spot marked, there's only a huge stone spire rising high above the landscape. Since there's nothing else around and the heat that day is unbearable, they decide to rest in the shade and set off again in the evening, so they'll reach the next — this time real — oasis around noon. Nara falls asleep quickly, and Hesiri spots a caravan in the distance. Ladrien's ghost, meanwhile, comments on her mistake with the map. The group is coming from the same direction, heading straight toward them. When they meet, they ask to share the shade and offer to travel together.

The kemet enforcer [from the Church's Parade chapters] will be named Betesh or Mnevis. Serapis is also a candidate

Nara discovers she has sharp senses and is very clever. The gnomes take her along on hunts, and she holds her own well enough. She'll start noticing tracks without knowing what they mean, and will start guessing whether someone is lying or not — all of which will be developed further in future books.

Aliserai 3: Shadows of war

by Leopold Ambry

In this outline: Book 3 · Act One · Act Two · Act Three · Character Reference — Quenlith (Quen) Tyrvin · Personality · Physical Description and Powers · Backstory (before entering the plot)

Book 3

This book will be mostly about Hesiri entering the city political war but from an angle of the revolutionist. The day-to-day reality of this is messy and half-improvised: she and Ladrien visit several noble houses who are supposed to be neutral, trying to read which way they'll bend, and warn members of the palace council about what's coming. Neither Hesiri nor the reader has a clean picture of what "being a revolutionist" actually looks like yet; she's caught up in the situation as much as she's shaping it. She and Ladrien work out of an abandoned guard tower that belongs to him, and alongside all of this she takes care of Nara and keeps training her, trying to keep at least one part of her life simple.

Due to Ladrien's earlier spree, many nobles see him as just as bad as Kilorn and are reluctant to join, which complicates Hesiri's efforts to bring the neutral houses over to her side from the very start.

Act One

She hears about a mass murderer targeting Kilorn's men, either killing them outright or driving them insane. In the beginning, while Hesiri tries to assess the situation, she is attacked by Rania. The two run into each other by accident, but Rania has never let go of the fact that Hesiri killed her mentor at the end of book one, and she decides on the spot that bringing Hesiri's head to the order will finally earn her the recognition she's wanted. Rania quickly realizes Hesiri is far too much for her and tries to escape, but she's killed moments later by Ladrien, who survived his death at the crimson feast. Ladrien had been following Rania for some time, waiting for the right moment to ambush her; when he sees her fighting someone in the dark, it looks like the perfect opening, and he intercepts and kills her while she's distracted. He doesn't realize until afterward that the person Rania was fighting was Hesiri — their reunion is a complete accident of timing on his part, not something he was looking for. Hesiri at first thinks she's hallucinating, something she's had to second-guess herself about before, but when he hugs her she realizes he's real.

Hesiri and Ladrien relationship: From the very first moment they meet up again it's clear that even though this is the first time they've met in eight months and haven't seen each other since, it's obvious that it's a rocky partnership. Hesiri, even though she accepts the new person Ladrien has become, prefers the old him and doesn't know the person he is now. Ladrien, expecting Hesiri to be the same ruthless person she was, and being manipulated by the entity on top of all that, can't return to how things were either. Neither of them can. This awkwardness lasts almost through the entire book, beginning here and growing more strained through the order sequence before it starts, slowly, to ease.

Nara and Ladrien relationship: She knows that Ladrien is her brother, but at this point in the story he might as well be a stranger, so Nara sees Ladrien largely through what Hesiri has told her and what she can make out for herself. She doesn't start calling him brother, but it's clear she does want to build the relationship of siblings. Ladrien, in

the state of mind he's in, has a few bad interactions with her at first, but he also doesn't reject the idea — he embraces having a sibling without falling into easy familiarity, not yet. That familiarity is more so a Book 3 — meaning later in this book's own arc — development than something settled now.

It turns out Ladrien sustained an injury that left him in constant pain. He survived by stealing eolith from his father and taking it while Hesiri wasn't looking. But the eolith isn't what's sustaining him anymore — he can't take more of it now — and something else has taken its place. He doesn't know what it is. Some nights he wonders if he's simply going insane. It speaks to him like a presence, a shadow with no shown form, calm when he complies with it and aggressive when he doesn't. Right now it's telling him Hesiri is too weak to be useful to him anymore. He ignores it, because he's just glad she's back. He's hiding all of this from her, not out of calculation but because he genuinely doesn't have an explanation to offer. He is now a far more powerful illusionist and a far more ruthless person than he was, and when Hesiri questions the change in him, he dismisses her, telling her this is the way it needs to be. The mass murderer hunting Kilorn's men is him — since the nobility is too frightened of Kilorn to move against him directly, this is the only war Ladrien is able to wage. Hesiri senses almost immediately that something is wrong with him, some wrongness underneath the change she can't name. She doesn't push it. Like him, she's just relieved that she and Nara aren't alone anymore, and for now that relief is stronger than her suspicion.

Kilorn gets a single chapter in act one establishing his ongoing work, separate from his deeper escalation later: he's deep in his own research, in the early discovery phase of what eolith actually does, refining and giving doses to August. He's strangely calm even while losing men to whatever's hunting them — he knows it's Ladrien doing the killing, and the knowledge doesn't rattle him; he simply factors it into his calculations like any other variable.

The order is finally wiped out by a kemet inquisitor at the end of act one. The Church has realized that the order's repeated failures — Hesiri's escape at the end of book one, the killing of the order's Executioner at the end of book two — mean the order has lost its grip entirely, and worse, that it now risks exposing the Church and the Inquisition's hand in controlling it from the start. The inquisitor isn't hunting anyone else and isn't pursuing some larger agenda; the order itself is the target, sent purely to erase the evidence of what it was used for.

Hesiri learns of the church's plan to kill the order right as it's about to happen. She wants to go there and save Jiskra and Ishet, but Ladrien objects, since it's dangerous and he thinks it's better if the church succeeds. Hesiri curses him out and tells him that if he doesn't help, she'll leave the tower and continue the revolution her own way. He agrees to join her once it's clear she's serious about this. They arrive too late to save most people, and the kemet inquisitor is far too strong to face directly. They only escape when a tunnel collapses on him and Nara teleports them out of there. She at least helps Amir and the young recruits escape, killing several church hands in the process.

Before meeting the inquisitor, the group meets Amir in the lower tunnels near the training hall, but the tunnel back collapses, forcing them to find a way up through the other end of the laboratory — a section of the facility Hesiri was never allowed to go. This section shows the truth behind the horrors of how the Aliserai are made, and shows that Nara is capable of leadership, largely by helping the group through it via teleporting them through narrow or unstable sections. We also see a map of the empire with several spots marked, including Iba'aresh, and it's heavily implied that those are other Aliserai bases — though neither Hesiri nor anyone else notices the map for what it is. They escape and say goodbye to Amir and the recruits they saved, since the city isn't safe for them.

Amir manages to escape with several young recruits, and Tahar escapes as well. Tahar tries to usurp some power in the city in the aftermath, but what's actually driving him isn't ambition anymore so much as compulsion — Tahar has always needed control over as much as possible, and with the order gone he's lost nearly all of it. He gets a single chapter here establishing this new, cornered state of his before it escalates through act two.

Act Two

At the start of act two, Quenlith (Quen) Tyrvin enters the story — not quietly, but in the middle of chaos. While Ladrien and Hesiri attempt to loot a warehouse as part of the ongoing effort to weaken Kilorn's supply lines, Ladrien knocks out a soldier and is immediately ambushed by a hooded figure who overpowers and ties him up through raw strength and skill alone before he can even mount a real fight back. She takes him to Lord Thesep, one of the neutral houses Hesiri and Ladrien have been courting, who has been trying to find out who's been driving his soldiers to madness and has been paying her for the work, promising her in return a way to contact her father, August.

Thesep, dismissive of Ladrien given his reputation, has no immediate interest in the revolution and threatens to hold him for a while — though he doesn't intend to kill him. Hesiri and Nara soon track Quen and Ladrien to the manor and move to save him by force. Quen nearly beats both of them before Thesep steps in to stop the fight and push for reason instead. All sides agree to hear each other out, and it's here that Quen's true identity is revealed: she's Hesiri's cousin, daughter of August from a brief relationship years before.

Thesep notes that he trusts Quen because she's brazen and tells the truth, a rare thing these days, and points out that she's very unlikely to actually attack her own cousin if push comes to shove — which Quen brazenly confirms herself. She goes further, telling him openly that if it ever came down to a choice between him and Hesiri, she'd choose Hesiri without hesitation. With that settled, Thesep becomes the first lord to actually join Hesiri and Ladrien's revolution, lending them Quen for the time being while they make plans to weaken or defeat Kilorn.

Much like Nara, Hesiri doesn't warm to Quen right away — her family has produced more monsters than not, and blood alone has never been reason enough to trust someone. But family means everything to Quen, and the moment she learns Hesiri is hers by blood, helping her stops being a job and starts being something closer to obligation. It's that insistence, more than anything Thesep says, that slowly wears down Hesiri's guard over the course of the book.

During this time, Quen starts teaching Hesiri swordplay and helps Nara get a better grip on the fundamentals of her magic. She also senses early on that something is off about Ladrien, and she's completely open about not liking him, saying so without much care for how it lands. She's just as blunt in pointing out that whatever is going on between Hesiri and Ladrien isn't in a good place, another example of her brazenness showing through. Quen joins the main group properly after this.

Nara's own want sharpens into focus this act: stopping Kilorn becomes her personal goal, not just something she helps Hesiri with. Kilorn killed her father, Mentareh Zerat, and caused the fall of her house — she never liked him, but he's the only blood connection she has left, and his death at Kilorn's hand gives her a stake in this fight that's entirely her own, separate from Hesiri's orbit.

Of the noble houses Hesiri and Ladrien have been courting, most that commit do so in small, partial ways — but the one house that could actually tip the balance against Kilorn is Lord Halfer's. Halfer refuses to commit any real

strength to the cause unless his daughter, Kemira, who Kilorn has kidnapped, is freed first. Rescuing her becomes the central undertaking of act two: if they pull it off, Halfer's house finally fights; if they don't, the resistance stays toothless against Kilorn specifically, whatever else it's accomplished.

What's left of Tahar through act two is closer to a caged animal clawing for any foothold of control he can find, even before he can name what exactly he's trying to regain. Since almost all of his old contacts only worked with him because of the leverage and control he held, he finds himself entirely alone, hiding out in Iba'aresh for most of the book, surviving ambush after ambush by the church and by Kilorn's people. He's shown sinking deeper across a handful of scenes rather than simply existing in this state: at one point he tries to rebuild a foothold by strong-arming a smuggling ring he once controlled, only to find they've already aligned themselves elsewhere and have no fear of him left; at another, cornered by church hands sent to finish what the inquisitor started, he survives only by drinking his own blood for the first time on the page this book, a habit that escalates toward the final fight with Hesiri rather than appearing there out of nowhere.

Kilorn himself spends this book deep in his own research rather than reacting to the political war as a whole. With the eolith finally in his hands, he's still in the discovery phase of what it actually does — he and the reader learn together that it amplifies magic, though Kilorn refuses to take it himself for most of the book, since he isn't a mage and has no reason to believe it would do anything for him. What he does do is refine and give it to August, again and again, building toward the dose that will eventually let August overpower his own daughter. Where Lord Mentareh Zerat, at the end of book one, seemed to be using the raw crystal to try to control the Nephites, Kilorn suspects there's something more to it than that, something beyond just handing August the power to do what he wants.

Kilorn's experiments are what will eventually give August the power to overwhelm Quen — but the eolith he's refining and feeding August hasn't caught up to that point yet.

His real endgame this book isn't August, and it isn't Hesiri — it's the inquisitor. Killing the inquisitor outright is something Kilorn considers impossible as long as the man is alive and active in the city, and refining eolith far enough to make that possible is the actual goal driving his research, independent of everything else going on around him. When the order is wiped out and it becomes clear the church is hunting both Tahar and Hesiri, Kilorn is the one who quietly tips off the church and the arch priest controlling the inquisitor that Hesiri is in the city — not out of any personal animosity, but because she's proven dangerous across the last two books, and because she's August's niece. If she dies to the inquisitor, Kilorn calculates that August will be left with one less distraction and one sharper focus: the work Kilorn actually wants from him.

Kilorn's other ongoing thread this book involves Meritara, a noble he manipulated and betrayed back in book two — she believed he was on her side until her mansion burned and she lost her fight against Zerat, a loss Kilorn's betrayal directly caused. She's been unable to leave his keep ever since, nearly eight months now, and it's clear she isn't entirely right in her mind anymore from the isolation. Kilorn has known her since he was a child, when she used to visit, and as far as he'll admit it to himself, he wants her to understand him and join him, since he respects her more than any other noble left in the city. What actually bothers him isn't that he's keeping her there — that part isn't even a question to him, since in his mind she can only ever be one of two things, contained or dead, never free and against him at once. What bothers him is that she still doesn't understand that. Her captivity gets no resolution on the page this book.

Near the end of the book, Kilorn's curiosity gets the better of him and he finally takes a dose himself — refined, not the raw crystal Zerat took — and feels almost nothing. It unsettles him slightly, but he reasons the refinement process itself may be the reason, and the unease passes quickly; if anything it sharpens his interest in what the substance might still be capable of rather than dampening it.

Much of Kilorn's progress this act doesn't come from his own hand alone — his right-hand man, Alexander, makes several breakthroughs with eolith and does much of the practical work of refining and testing it, freeing Kilorn to focus on August and on the inquisitor problem. Through Alexander, the reader sees the research thread as an actual undertaking with setbacks and small victories, not just a state Kilorn sits in.

While investigating where Kilorn might be holding Kemira, Hesiri, Ladrien, and Nara cross paths with a group of Per Ankh investigators operating in green capes — the same group glimpsed back in book one — who are working independently of the palace council and the nobility. The Per Ankh make clear they don't trust the nobility and don't believe the council will move against Kilorn unless the emperor intervenes directly, which they doubt will happen short of something far more serious than what's happened so far, and they'd rather it not come to that. They reveal that Kemira is being held in Kilorn's stronghold. The group waits until Kilorn and Alexander are both away from the keep before making their move.

Nara seems to take a real interest in the Per Ankh from this first meeting on. She asks more questions of them than anyone else in the group does, watching how they operate — independent, methodical, answering to no noble house or council — with something closer to fascination than simple curiosity. Nothing comes of it yet this book, just a seed of interest quietly planted here rather than anything either she or the group makes note of at the time.

The rescue itself runs them into August, who Kilorn left behind specifically to guard the keep — and, unknown to the rescue party at the time, Meritara — while he deals with something else in the city: an attempt to control a broken Nephite somewhere in the underground tunnels. August doesn't intervene out of any larger scheme; he's simply there when the group moves on the dungeon to free Kemira, and he reacts to the attack on the keep he's guarding. It's this interception that brings Quen face to face with her father for the very first time. Her usual brazenness fails her entirely — she can't find a single word to say, and she holds her ground scratching behind her right ear the whole time, nerves showing through even as she stands there. August, for his part, hadn't known she was there, and the shock of finally seeing his daughter is enough that he simply runs rather than fight. It isn't a fight lost, but two people too stunned to act, that lets the group get away with Kemira.

Quen doesn't leave the group's side after this. Whatever pull Thesep's original promise once had on her, it's Hesiri — her family — that keeps her staying and fighting from here on, and alongside the rest of the group she starts trying to understand exactly what's been done to August, since it's becoming clear that as long as Kilorn has his hand on him, he can't simply be reasoned with or reached.

They free Kemira. In the aftermath, the Per Ankh investigators become loose allies of the group going forward — not fully trusted, and helping only in small ways, but aligned against Kilorn for their own reasons. It's only afterward, once the group is already working alongside them, that the Per Ankh reveal Kilorn has forces in Anubet as well, a thread that pulls the story toward book four.

Act two closes on Kemira's rescue and its fallout — Halfer's house finally committing to the fight, the Per Ankh becoming loose allies, and Quen now fully bound to the group and to unraveling what's been done to August — with the encounter at the keep setting up Kilorn's response heading into act three.

Act Three

Kilorn responds to the rescue by reading August's failure to stop it — and the fact that the mere sight of his own daughter was enough to freeze him in the field — as a weakness that needs correcting. He hands August an upgraded dose of eolith, the result of Alexander's breakthroughs catching up to what August actually needs to function without hesitation. On it, August seeks Quen out again early in act three, this time in the open, and unlike their first meeting, he doesn't hold back. Partway through the fight he starts controlling flame against her — the very thing she's afraid of — and for the first time it isn't just her father she's afraid of, it's him wielding the one thing that already terrifies her. He beats her badly, and it's only when Hesiri steps in that he stops, some flicker of awareness cutting through the eolith long enough for him to realize what he's doing. He runs again after that, leaving Quen bruised but alive. The damage to how he's understood is done regardless: his magic is more powerful now, but unrefined and unfocused, and he himself is erratic and vicious in a way that has nothing to do with the cold, controlled fury he carried into this book. This is the proof, for Quen and for the reader, that whatever Kilorn has done to him has compromised him as much as it's strengthened him.

During one night where Tahar attempts to kill Kilorn and fails, he's hunted all around the city — first the scared, cornered version of him that defines his act two — until he's finally caught by Hesiri and killed in a fierce battle at the end of act three. Not before drinking several vials of his own blood and killing nearly two hundred soldiers.

Partway through that rampage, Ladrien catches up to him alone. What comes out in the confrontation is something he's never actually said out loud before: he's never gotten over Tahar stabbing him back in book one, and however much distance he thought he'd put on it since, it clearly hasn't gone anywhere. He goes after Tahar meaning to end it himself — but Tahar in this state is well beyond anything Ladrien is actually equipped to handle, blood-frenzied and past reasoning with, and he's overpowered fast. It's only Nara, catching up just in time to see it happening, who saves him: she teleports him clear in the last possible second, and rather than trying to talk him down from a distance, she simply throws her arms around him and holds on as tight as she can, refusing to let go no matter how hard he strains against her. For a moment he actually considers forcing her off — he's stronger than her, and it would take almost nothing — but something in just being held like that gets through where words wouldn't have, and he decides against it, going still in her arms instead. He doesn't go back. Tahar's rampage continues without him until Hesiri finally catches up to end it herself, the story picking back up from there exactly as already laid out.

The fight echoes and inverts the one that closed book one, where Hesiri was the wild, out-of-control one and Tahar was composed. Here the roles are reversed: Tahar is the one who has finally snapped completely, and Hesiri, for the first time, is the one in control — not cold control, but clarity. She isn't fighting to destroy the monster she once saw in him; somewhere in the fight she realizes she's looking at a scared animal that has to be put down, and that his side of things was never the right one, given what it's made of him. For the first time in the book, she leaves a fight genuinely believing she's done the right thing.

That same night, while the rest of the group is consumed with Tahar, Kilorn presses his advantage on a second front: he sends soldiers to storm the abandoned guard tower Hesiri and Ladrien have been operating out of all book. It's undefended at the time, save for Quen, still healing from what August did to her and the only one left there when the attack comes. It's a genuinely hard fight for her, weakened as she is — nothing like the effortless work she made of Ladrien back at the start of the act. True to her own code even here, she isn't just cutting everyone down as they come — she slashes and beats her way through mostly at random in the chaos of it, but

chooses to knock out rather than kill whenever the fight actually gives her that option, only finishing the ones who don't leave her any other choice. She wins, but the tower catches fire around her in the process, likely something knocked loose in the fighting, and the flames start closing in before she can get clear. Rather than leave empty-handed, she throws down her sword and hauls one of the soldiers she'd knocked out over her shoulder instead, carrying him out of the building with her rather than leaving him to burn. Once outside, she gets a moment to look back at the tower burning behind her — the one thing she's been afraid of her whole life, right there, close enough to touch. Some unnamed impulse pulls her hand out toward the fire before she catches herself and yanks it back just as fast, saying nothing about it to anyone afterward.

The soldier she carried out wakes up grateful rather than hostile, and it loosens his tongue without anyone having to force anything out of him. Of his own volition, he gives the group two things that matter: that Kilorn has allies coming in from the north, and that there's something worth looking into happening in Anubet. Neither means much to anyone in the moment, but it's the thread that pulls the story toward book four.

The reader only learns, right at the very end, that Meritara has escaped the keep.

Ladrien is relieved when Hesiri beats Tahar, and it's here that he finally says that he loves her — something he was building up to from book 1 — and Hesiri says it back. From that point on, Ladrien no longer sees the entity but remains pragmatic, albeit to a much lesser degree, while Hesiri changes her non-killing rule from this point on but never returns to the killer she was in book 1.

Character Reference — Quenlith (Quen) Tyrvin

(Included here per request, as this is her first outline appearance. Her established events take priority over any conflicting outline material.)

Personality

She's brazen, often saying what needs (and doesn't need) to be said, regardless of how awkward it makes the room. She handles grief or trauma with weird jokes and awkward laughter at first, not knowing another way to process it. She's calmer and generally better-adjusted than her uncle. She acts a bit childish for her age, a sign that her childhood, while not as bad as the others', was still missing real parenthood. When she's nervous, she has a habit of scratching behind her right ear, a small tell that gives away the moments her bravado slips. She does not kill, seeing capture and delivery to the law as a just punishment and monetary reward helps. She has pyrophobia, a phobia of open flame. Family means everything to her — once she learns Hesiri is her cousin, helping her stops being a favor or a job and becomes something closer to obligation.

Physical Description and Powers

Tall, dark-haired, with deep blue eyes. A three-quarter elf, which keeps her looking young despite her age, and her right ear is slightly turned outward compared to the left, a habit of scratching behind it when she's nervous. She ties her long dark hair back with a small ribbon into a single ponytail. Strong swordfighter, on top of her magic, elves in this world grow stronger the more they train, so she sits in a bracket where Hesiri would need to activate

her bull tattoo to a lesser degree just to make a fight against Quen a genuine challenge. She uses a traditional khopesh as her weapon. Her magic is summoning, centered on ravens fast as crossbow bolts and nearly indestructible, which is where her nickname "the bloody raven" comes from. Her magic works by shaping raw power into the form of creatures she already knows, which makes it heavily dependent on study rather than raw instinct — she can't summon what she hasn't learned. She favors ravens specifically because she finds them majestic, and because they're great hunters of shiny things, a trait she finds fitting. For most of the story, ravens are essentially all she summons, even her large monsters are, underneath it, just oversized flightless ravens: two-meter-tall juggernauts that cause destruction until they're put down or dismissed. She can control them directly if she chooses to, but it's usually easier on her mind just to let them loose and let instinct take over instead.

Backstory (before entering the plot)

Biological cousin to Hesiri, daughter of August, born from a brief relationship he had with a full-elf woman during his younger years. She spent her earlier years as a bounty hunter in the northern empire, searching for her father and tracking him all the way to the capital. She's thirty-seven years old.

Aliserai 4: Iron city

by Leopold Ambry

In this outline: The City of Anubet · Act One · Act Two · Act Three

The City of Anubet

Anubet, the Iron Gate of the North, is the empire's great metal bulwark — a city built for one purpose and one purpose only, holding the line against everything that lives beyond it. Its walls rise twenty-five meters, forged from a pure iron that hasn't rusted once in four thousand years of the empire's history — because the iron itself was never truly ordinary to begin with. Both it and the walls raised from it were a gift from the Emperor himself, and that origin shows in small, uncanny ways: the metal never rusts, and even under the region's blistering sun it never heats the way iron should, staying cool to the touch no matter the season. The city's church has taken this as its charge, presiding over rites said to be what actually maintains the walls' unnatural properties — whether that's genuine divine upkeep or simply a story the church tells to justify its place in a city that otherwise has no real use for it, the empire has never bothered to clarify, and Anubet has never bothered to ask.

The walls themselves aren't solid — they're hollow through most of their length, and that hollow interior houses the bulk of the city's standing army, garrisoned inside the very structure they're meant to defend. The surface tells the walls' long history plainly: centuries of ballista bolts, arrows, spears, and hurled stone have dented and pitted the iron so thoroughly that a person could plausibly climb it on the damage alone, if the siege weaponry lining the top — thick, permanent, every piece of it aimed north — didn't make the attempt suicidal long before they got close. The northern tribes throw themselves at those walls like something possessed, refusing again and again to accept the emperor's rule over them, and a siege on Anubet isn't a crisis, it's a monthly occurrence, one more entry in a streak of failures stretching back as far as anyone can count.

Everything about the city exists to feed that fight. Anubet is a hub of forges and metalworking, its skyline more furnace-smoke than rooftop, and its barracks house standing armies large enough to make the constant sieges look almost routine by comparison. It doesn't have ordinary citizens so much as it has the descendants of people who came here once, generations ago, and simply never managed to become anything else — failed settlers, failed merchants, people who meant to move on and didn't, left trying to carve an ordinary life out of a city that has never once stopped being a war.

Act One

Fourth book opens with the group arriving in Anubet, a small army already having been spotted entering Iba'aresh behind them in Kilorn's colors — clear proof he has allies somewhere in the north, though what that actually means is left for later. Once in the city, Hesiri, Nara, Ladrien, and Quen learn Anubet is governed by a sitting council of three, and start trying to work out where the real balance of power between the three of them actually lies.

Before making any move on the council directly, the group crosses paths with an aurmancer named Elseth. Quen recognizes him immediately — she once caught him as a bounty years earlier, but let him go after discovering the charges against him were mostly fabricated and that he was just a kid at the time. That old history is what puts

Elseth in the group's path here rather than a random encounter, and it hints that the Church wanted him captured back then for reasons that had little to do with whatever he was actually accused of. He joins the group before they move against the council, though it's clear early on that being an aurmancer isn't something he's ever really made peace with — he can do it, he just doesn't want to, and for now nobody in the group pushes him on it.

With Elseth now with them, the group breaks into the council building to get a real look at how power actually moves between the three members. What they find is that two of the three consistently vote and act in lockstep — one of them a woman operating under a different name than the one she'll later be known by, and the other a man who seems less like a genuine ally to her and more like someone she's leveraging, coerced into agreement rather than persuaded into it. The group doesn't yet know why, or that the woman is actually Kilorn's sister, Indira Ventr, working under a false identity — that piece only comes together afterward, once they've had time to dig into what they saw. The break-in itself was only ever meant to gather proof, not to move against her directly, but Indira is already aware of them, and turns the search into a trap of her own, sending guards down on the group mid-search. What was meant to be quiet infiltration turns into a running fight to escape the building.

In the chaos of that escape, the group tries to spring a trap of their own on her rather than just get clear. Hesiri waits hidden inside a room Indira is known to always pass through — and it should work. It doesn't. The moment Indira's hand touches the door handle, she's already running, bolting away before she's even opened the door or laid eyes on what's waiting for her inside. Quen moves to cut her off as she flees, throwing a fake-out strike meant to bait a reaction before finishing her from the real angle — and Indira dodges that too, slipping past the feint clean, which leaves Quen genuinely baffled: a fake-out is built specifically to be unpredictable, and there's no way she should have been able to read it coming. The one hit that actually connects through any of this is pure accident on the group's side: Elseth throws a gold coin at her elsewhere in the chaos, more reflex than plan, and it catches her across the head. Even hit, she still gets away, slipping loose and staying hidden in Anubet rather than fleeing to Iba'aresh — the political ground there too valuable for her to give up after one failed move against her. The group is left genuinely stunned by how she escaped everything else thrown at her, with no explanation for what they just watched. The reason isn't given here. What actually happened is that Indira has a form of future sight, and gold's anti-magic property is what nullified it in that one instant, letting Elseth's coin land when nothing else could. That explanation only comes later, near the end of the book, tying back into what Nara first starts to suspect watching her speech in act three.

One of the major arcs of this book will also be that Hesiri is kidnapped by the church in the same chaos, snatched away by Am-Heh's people while Indira's guards have the rest of the group scattered and fighting to get clear. When the group regroups and realizes Hesiri isn't with them, their first assumption is that Indira took her, given whose trap they'd just walked into — it's only once they start digging that they realize Indira had nothing to do with it, and that the church moved on Hesiri independently, using the confusion Indira created as cover. The arch priest Am-Heh, who knows the church has been looking for her, intends to turn her into a semi-inquisitor — or a kemet Aliserai, rather — by injecting her with the same substance they put into other inquisitors. He tortures her for several chapters.

Act Two

A long search follows, with the rest of the group — now Ladrien, Nara, Elseth, and Quen — working together to find her. It's Quen's tracking skills that finally lead them to Am-Heh's laboratory.

The moment of the rescue itself belongs to Ladrien. When they finally break through to where she's being held, it's Ladrien who finds her first — curled up in the corner of the room, small in a way nothing about her has ever read as before. She doesn't ask what's happening or reach for a weapon. She just whispers that she wants to go home. Ladrien takes in the room around them — Am-Heh's equipment, whatever's been done to her still laid out in plain view — and he doesn't say a word about any of it. He doesn't ask her what happened. He wraps her in his own cape and carries her out, silent the whole way, past Elseth, Nara, and Quen still fighting to hold the exit clear. Elseth, still uneasy about leaning on his own power, uses just enough of it to help hold the line — the first time since joining the group that he's actually called on it directly, even if only partway. There's nothing performative about it and nothing that needs explaining between them; it's just the one thing he can actually do for her right now, and he does it without hesitating. Even Quen, brazen as she usually is, finds herself without a word to say once Hesiri is actually pulled out of that room — the sight of her leaves nothing to joke about this time.

He reveals that he is the original creator of the Aliserai. He's also the one that poisoned her mother and told the Aliserai to recruit her afterwards since he saw a great potential in her after what her uncle did. He made the original tattoos. Hesiri stabs him with the shard of Illya in the head during the chaos of the rescue, the same blow that would kill anyone else outright — and he simply doesn't die from it. No stagger, no visible damage that lingers, nothing that reads as a wound slowing him down. He uses the chaos of the rescue to slip away and escape rather than staying to finish anything, leaving the stab as the clearest proof yet of exactly how far outside normal human limits he actually is. It isn't framed as him surviving something that should have killed him through toughness or luck — it's framed as the wound simply not applying to him the way it would to anyone else, which is a much colder and more unsettling thing for Hesiri to have just learned firsthand. As he flees the lab in the chaos, Quen sends one of her large summoned monsters after him. She never finds out whether it caught him — only that the creature itself ends up dead, and she says as much afterward, unsure what that means for whether he actually died. Hesiri tells her plainly that he's alive, she's sure of it.

Am-Heh sees magic as an unearned gift and evolution as the only power that has to prove itself. Magic is luck; evolution is judgment. What survives selection is real — what's merely granted is not. But he knows selection is its own danger: any power that chooses is a power that can be corrupted by the one doing the choosing. Power given without sacrifice is worse — untested, unearned, and answerable to no one.

Act Three

Hesiri's Post-Torture Upgrade (condensed)

Nearly dies, recovers stronger even without tattoos active. Blood more potent → tattoos more powerful, body stronger/more durable overall.

Only 2 tattoos upgraded (operation incomplete): snake and scales.

- Snake — Hand of Creation: now covers whole arm. No longer limited to chains and knives — can conjure basically any spectral weapon: swords, spears, hammers, and more, scaling up to sizes far larger than her own body. Can sustain multiple conjured weapons at once and also she can summon spectral chains harder than steel to bind enemies.

- Scales (calves): originally cancels her own momentum, no side effects. Upgraded: extends that effect to anything she touches with her feet. Cost is still her own blood, like all tattoos.
- New orb in chest: second heartbeat, fillable with her own blood; lets her run 2 tattoos at once.

Negative effects (mostly mental): feels less human, more weapon. Compounded by age (18) and existing trauma. No way to know if Am-Heh altered her mind — the uncertainty itself eats at her. Keeps distance from Ladrien/others for now. Also half-aware he's not wrong that her life before wasn't much to lose.

With Hesiri still recovering and clearly not in the right headspace to fight, the rest of the group has to carry the work of investigating the council further on their own. It's during this stretch that two kemet Inquisitors — dispatched by the Church, still hunting Elseth after all this time — finally catch up with the group.

Elseth's relationship with his own power comes to a head here. He's struggled to actually accept being an aurmancer for a long time now — even with the rest of the group treating it as a complete non-issue, it's taken him this long to start coming around to using it at all, and what he leaned on during Hesiri's rescue was only ever partial, more necessity than anything like comfort. Decades of the Church hunting him specifically have left him genuinely afraid of Inquisitors above almost anything else, and that fear is what nearly costs the group here. It's Ladrien, Quen, and Elseth who end up facing the two Inquisitors directly, and it's a hard, close fight — but they kill both of them. In the aftermath, Elseth takes their weapons for himself, chakrams and gold rings, and starts working with them going forward — the first real sign that he's beginning to actually own what he is rather than just tolerate it.

Meanwhile, Nara and Hesiri spend the same stretch digging into the council from a different angle, catching one of its public speeches and watching Indira closely from the crowd. It's here that Nara first realizes something is genuinely wrong with Indira beyond just being Kilorn's plant — a small, unplaced hint at some kind of future sight in her, nothing confirmed or explained yet, just enough for Nara to clock that something about her doesn't add up. Nara also spends part of this time trying to pull Hesiri out of her own head a little, and it works, at least in some small way. By the time the group reconnects, piecing together what Elseth's fight uncovered alongside what Nara noticed watching Indira gives them the full picture — including, finally, an answer to the one thing that's genuinely stuck with them since act one: why every attack that day went wide except for Elseth's coin. Indira's future sight explains the dodges; gold's anti-magic property explains why the coin, alone out of everything thrown at her, actually landed.

Future Sight (how it works in this world): What the sight shows is fixed and unchangeable — if someone looks three seconds ahead and sees themselves getting hit, they get hit, full stop, no matter what they try to do differently in between. The vision isn't a warning to dodge around, it's just the truth of what already happens. The range of it is adjustable, not fixed: pushing further out or pulling in closer is a conscious choice, traded off against how much of the user's own magic it costs to hold the window open — but there's almost always a hard ceiling nobody can push past no matter how much they're willing to spend. For Indira specifically, that ceiling sits at around three seconds. The unchangeable part creates its own strange effect in ordinary use, too: if someone tries to open a door and their own sight shows them not opening it, it's rarely because something physically stops them — it's usually just that knowing the outcome in advance is enough to make them not want to anymore. Seeing the future doesn't only show what happens; it tends to quietly remove the reason to still try for anything else. It also never skips the cause behind an outcome, only ever confirms it: if someone tortures a prisoner and their sight shows them walking

away already knowing what they needed, that's not the sight handing them the answer for free — it's simply telling them, in advance, that the torture is going to work. Whatever it would ordinarily take to get there still has to actually happen; the vision just confirms the ending was never in doubt.

Somewhere in this same stretch, Quen finds herself drawn to the flames again — closer this time than she's let herself get since the tower burned in book three, her hand stopping only a hair's breadth from the fire itself before she pulls it back, still not quite ready to let it touch her.

With everything they've now learned, the group moves against Indira Ventr a second time — though it's worth being clear about what they're actually going in for. Nobody but Ladrien has much interest in killing her outright; the plan is capture, not execution, taking Kilorn's inside link out of the city's politics rather than making a martyr or a body count out of her. Ladrien alone wouldn't lose any sleep if it ended in her death instead, though even he doesn't push for it as the goal. During the fight, Quen summons another of her large monsters to cause chaos, and the destruction that follows starts tearing the building apart around them, splitting the group up as fire spreads through the structure. Hesiri and Ladrien end up cut off on a bridge connecting two of the towers, and the heat finishes what the fighting started — the bridge cracks violently down the middle, the far half already giving way beneath them. Hesiri doesn't hesitate. She drives her snake tattoo into the stone on either side, and the glowing chains built for binding enemies snap taut around the bridge itself instead, holding several tons of collapsing masonry level long enough for Ladrien to clear the gap. It isn't clean — her arm shakes with the strain the whole time, blood running freely to feed it — but it holds. Ladrien doesn't say much once he's across, just enough to make clear what they're both already thinking: the Hesiri from before the torture would have been crushed flat under that weight without ever getting the chance to try.

In the same collapse, a large section of the council building comes down as flames erupt through it, with Indira swallowed by the blaze — not the ending anyone actually planned for, though not one anyone in the group finds themselves mourning either.

The group returns to the city of Iba'aresh.

Aliserai 5: Flames of Ibaaresh

by Leopold Ambry

In this outline: Act One — The Inquisitor Fight and the Bite · Act Two — The Lockdown and the Negotiation · Act Three — Escalation · Act Four — The Long Stalemate · Act Five — The Finale

Act One — The Inquisitor Fight and the Bite

- The trio returns to the city. Hesiri, transformed by what Am-Heh did to her in Book 4, fights alongside August and Quen against the kemet Inquisitor.
- August dies here — the eolith corrupting his blood leaves him marked and unstable in a way the Inquisitor can sense and exploit, giving him an opening he wouldn't have against an unmarked opponent. In the same stretch of the fight, the Inquisitor crushes him outright.
- The Inquisitor catches Quen and slashes her, but Hesiri manages to catch enough of the blow to keep it from being fatal — the one clear win Hesiri pulls from an otherwise losing fight.
- The Inquisitor "wins" the encounter, but doesn't walk away clean — he's injured too.
- We sit with the aftermath: Hesiri dragging Quen to safety, Quen fighting her the whole way — kicking and screaming, refusing to leave even as she's carried off, having just watched her father die in front of her. This is the emotional low point of the act, and it needs room before the next beat lands.

Concurrent with this fight: while the Inquisitor is occupied and the city's attention is elsewhere, Kilorn moves on the palace council and wipes it out completely. In the council's last act before falling, they send a letter out by bird — its contents unknown to the reader at this point, just a courier bird leaving a burning building.

- Later revealed: that letter was the council's final order, directing the southern army to march on and besiege Iba'aresh.
- The letter is received and read by a man in heavy armor — introduced here without fanfare, no name or context given yet — who treats the order as a trivial, almost routine matter. He begins preparing an imperial army and marches toward the capital.
- This plants the southern army's arrival (already established as the book's closing threat, mustered "due to the rebellion and the city being in flames") much earlier than it previously surfaced, and gives it a face and a point of origin instead of appearing abstractly at the end.

The Bite

- After the fight, still injured, the Inquisitor encounters a strange, unassuming human — later revealed to be Alexander, and later still, Apep. This is Apep's first on-page appearance in Book 5, though nobody (reader included, on first read) knows it yet.
- This figure tries to kill him. The Inquisitor is dragged through several buildings by something and left with two deep, bleeding puncture wounds in his side.
- This is the chaos plague bite — unnamed and unexplained on the page here. The only confirmation comes later, in Book 6, when the Emperor is shown carrying identical wounds, retroactively revealing Apep did this to both of them.

Indira Ventr — The Plant

- Following her exposure at the end of Book 4, Kilorn doesn't discard his sister as a liability — he weaponizes her. Rather than lose her as an asset, he sends her into the city to "defect" to the resistance. It's never real. She arrives already working for him.
- She's not trusted immediately, given whose sister she is, but she's patient about earning her way in — small, deniable acts of good faith at first, nothing that reads as suspicious.
- Her actual work starts quietly in this act: a bad tip that gets a resistance runner killed, a supply cache that goes missing, a leak that reads as coincidence rather than betrayal. None of it should be legible as sabotage on a first read — it should look like the ordinary bad luck of a city under siege. This thread runs underneath Acts One through Four, small and easy to miss until the pattern is visible in hindsight.
- For now she keeps her head down, doing the quiet work and waiting for a real opening to get closer to people who actually matter to the resistance's operations.

Act Two — The Lockdown and the Negotiation

- From this point until the finale, the Inquisitor wanders the city, weakened, doing little. The plague is working on him slowly and invisibly to everyone but the reader (once they know to look back).
- Nobody understands what's happening to him. Without an explanation, people simply steer clear rather than confront him — he's still frightening even diminished, and nobody wants to find out why he's like this.
- This is what clears the space for the book's other threads to escalate on their own terms without the Inquisitor intervening: Kilorn bleeding soldiers as both the resistance and the Church grind down his nobles, Hesiri becoming the de facto face and spearhead of the resistance, and Kilorn's accelerating, riskier timeline as her reputation forces his hand.
- Kilorn reveals a staggering force nobody expected and takes the city — with this, an inner wall goes up and the city is sealed. No civilians are permitted to leave; Iba'aresh becomes a closed trap rather than just a warzone.
- Hesiri, the group, and the Per Ankh shift into an enforcer role: protecting civilians and even scattered, cut-off Emperor's soldiers who Kilorn's forces are hunting down piecemeal inside the walls.
- A natural division of labor sets in as the resistance grows too large for any one approach: Elseth and Ladrien take on the actual running of it — safehouses, patrol coordination, the unglamorous logistics of keeping a swelling movement fed, hidden, and organized — while Hesiri spends most of her time out in the open and alone, moving from crisis to crisis pulling survivors out rather than sitting in on the planning. Nobody decides this outright; it's simply what she's suited for and drawn to, and it deepens her isolation even as she becomes more visible to the city than ever — the face of the resistance, but rarely actually in the room with the people holding it together.
- Ladrien is the one who actually reads what this isolation means. Hesiri is fighting like the ruthless combatant she used to be again, and to everyone else that reads as recovery — but he knows her well enough to see it for what it actually is: if she were mentally well, she wouldn't choose to spend nearly all her time alone. The competence is real, but it isn't health; it's the trauma from what Am-Heh did to her in Book 4 still sitting underneath everything, just quiet under the fighting instead of loud. He doesn't say anything yet.

- Alongside the direct fighting against Kilorn's forces, the group's attention splits across two hunts: Kilorn himself, pursued by the core group, and the arch priest, who vanished from the picture right after the Inquisitor was bitten — a thread Nara takes up on her own at first, embedding with the Per Ankh investigators to track him down rather than staying folded into the main group's work, since Quen isn't yet fit to join her.
- Quen, still healing from the wound she took in Act One, spends the early part of this act laid up — genuinely hurt, and furious about it, since sitting still while the city falls apart isn't something she does well. But set against a siege that will end up stretching nearly a year, her recovery is fast: within a few weeks she's back on her feet, elvish resilience closing the gap that would keep anyone else down far longer. As soon as she's fit, she joins Nara's hunt for the arch priest, taking point as the group's vanguard — cutting down the monsters that have infested the tunnels beneath the city since the council fell.
- This stretch is where Hesiri's role as the resistance's face hardens into something more literal — she's no longer just a symbol people rally around, she's the one physically holding lines and pulling people out of Kilorn's reach.
- First hint, easy to miss: Alexander is seen producing several batches of noticeably weaker, diluted eolith on the side, separate from the refined stock he hands Kilorn. He waves it off as minor side experiments when anyone asks — nothing that reads as significant yet, just Alexander tinkering the way he always does.
- A second, quieter version of the same hint: among Kilorn's soldiers, complaints start circulating about the drinking water tasting off — barrel arguments near Kilorn's base become common enough to be a running, background detail rather than a plot point. Nobody in the resistance hears about this directly yet; it's the kind of thing that only becomes meaningful once the reader knows to connect it.
- Indira, continued: with Elseth and Ladrien buried in the work of running the resistance, Elseth notices her — sharp, capable, and underused for someone supposedly this committed — and recruits her to help manage the growing operation. She accepts. It's exactly the kind of access her actual mission needs, but the collaboration becomes something more than access almost immediately: the two of them are constantly in each other's orbit now, and a bond starts forming between them, awkward at first — neither quite sure how to be around the other, both a little too guarded for it to be easy — but real despite that. Her relationship with him deepens through the rest of this act, and it starts to become something she didn't plan for. She came in as a weapon with a job to do; somewhere in the middle of doing it, she's started to actually care about one of the people she's supposed to help destroy. She doesn't act on this yet, and doesn't fully admit it to herself — it sits underneath everything she does, unresolved.

The Third Faction — Negotiation

- A third faction emerges: skeptical, frightened nobles who've kept their own soldiers loyal and start hoarding supplies and resources now that the city is locked down and nothing is getting in or out.
- Hesiri opens negotiations with these houses directly — this act is the diplomatic push, trying to talk them into joining or at least cooperating with the resistance while things are still stable enough for reason to work.

Act Three — Escalation

- Even as she keeps thinking of herself as more weapon than person, the actual use of her power on this stretch cuts against that belief without her fully admitting it: her abilities from Am-Heh make saving people meaningfully easier, and she starts testing more of what she can do specifically because there's finally a use for it

that isn't just killing. This isn't a clean turnaround — she doesn't decide she's human because of it — but it's the first real crack in how she sees herself, seeded here for later payoff rather than resolved in this book.

- As the siege drags on, supplies inside the city start visibly dwindling, and the third faction's negotiations sour because of it — nobles who were cautiously cooperative in Act Two escalate as their hoarded resources start looking less like caution and more like the only thing standing between their people and starvation. Hesiri's approach has to shift from mostly reason to increasingly forcing the issue, since goodwill alone stops working once scarcity sets in.
- This is where Ladrien finally says something. He tells her directly what he's been sitting on since Act Two — that working herself ragged alone isn't strength, it's avoidance, and that he refuses to let her keep treating herself as nothing but a weapon just because it's easier than sitting with what Am-Heh actually did to her. It isn't a gentle conversation, and she doesn't fully agree with him in the moment, but it lands. Afterward, she starts pulling back from working alone and steps into helping negotiate with the third faction directly, right as their hoarding and the city's dwindling supplies are pushing those talks toward collapse — the first real sign that Ladrien's getting through to her is a change in behavior, not a change in what she says about herself.
- Second hint: Alexander's "side experiments" with weaker eolith batches continue and grow slightly more frequent, still brushed off as inconsequential tinkering — but paired with the escalating scarcity and unrest in the city, a careful reader can start to wonder what he's actually diluting it for, since it's clearly not for Kilorn's soldiers' combat strength. The water complaints among Kilorn's men continue in the background as well, mentioned in passing rather than investigated by anyone.
- The act closes on Nara, Quen, and the Per Ankh finding the arch priest dead in the sewers beneath the city — and it lands as a genuine setback rather than a win, though not the one anyone expected. He's clearly been dead for some time already, likely killed not long after the Inquisitor was bitten, which means the leash on the kemet Inquisitor was never gradually loosening over the course of the book — it was already gone from nearly the very start. That's the harder realization Nara and the Per Ankh have to sit with: they weren't tracking down a fading thread of control, there was never any control left to find — the Inquisitor's rampage hasn't been half-random since the bite, it's been fully unmoored the entire time, and nobody in the city, resistance or otherwise, has had any way to predict or check him for almost the whole siege. It also confirms Kilorn was already moving against the Church's remaining authority in the city well before the finale, cutting off one more power that could have organized against him — the group just didn't realize how early that door had actually closed. For Quen specifically, this lands even harder: with the one target she'd fixed all her grief and rage onto gone before she ever got the chance to face him, she starts mentally shutting down, the fight finally draining out of her all at once. It's Nara who pulls her back, begging her that the city still needs her, that she can't just stop now. Quen agrees, reluctantly, and pulls herself back together enough to function.
- Indira, continued: by the end of this act, she recognizes what she feels for Elseth for what it is — but the recognition comes with the understanding that it's already too late to change anything. She's too deep into what she's doing, too bound to Kilorn, or too afraid of what walking away would cost her, to act on it. There's no version of this where she gets to have both the mission and him. She doesn't confide this to anyone, least of all Elseth.

Act Four — The Long Stalemate

- The Emperor's Neferit continue guarding the palace exactly as before, indifferent to everything happening in the rest of the city — killing anyone who approaches the palace grounds (Arkevath) without hesitation, as if the siege isn't happening at all.
- The kemet Inquisitor keeps wandering the city through this whole stretch, killing seemingly at random. Nobody — resistance, Kilorn's forces, or civilians — can predict or explain him, so all sides simply treat him like a natural disaster to be avoided rather than an enemy to be fought.
- Meanwhile, Kilorn's right hand Alexander keeps refining eolith and hits staggering progress — enough that it starts to read as almost too much, a hint that what he's doing is outpacing anyone's ability to control it, Kilorn included.
- Quen throws herself fully into the war effort through this stretch. Her ravens become a lifeline for communication across the city, and she discovers she can actually make them speak, carrying messages aloud rather than on paper — which makes anything sent through them effectively impossible to intercept: even if someone catches one of her ravens, there's no message to pull off it and no way to make the bird talk on command, nothing physical to steal and no way to force the words out of it. She also takes to fighting bandit groups that have sprung up in the chaos. In one of these fights, she kills a regular kemet Inquisitor and gets the confirmation she needed for herself: they're mutants, made rather than born, which means killing the one who actually killed her father would have meant nothing, no different than breaking the weapon that struck him rather than the hand that swung it.
- The siege stretches on for nearly a year in total before the southern army finally arrives — this act is the quiet, mounting-tension stretch of that stalemate, the calm that makes the finale's break feel earned rather than sudden.

Indira's Discovery and Death

- Indira's sabotage has been running the whole book — the bad tips, the missing supplies, the leaks — but it finally becomes undeniable here. Elseth catches her in the act, killing a resistance member outright, with no room left for coincidence or doubt.
- She doesn't try to explain herself or beg. She runs.
- Elseth chases her down. The pursuit carries the weight of everything he's realizing in real time — that whatever they had may have been part of the job from the start, or may have become real somewhere along the way, and he has no way to know which, or whether it even matters now.
- When he catches her, he's forced to kill her. There's no confession, no last word that resolves anything — he's left with the act itself and none of the why.
- This should land as a private, unresolved grief for Elseth specifically — not shared with the group in any detail, and not something he has an answer for going into Book 6. Whether he ever learns the full truth (that it was a ruse from the start, engineered by Kilorn) is a thread that can be left open rather than settled on the page here.

Act Five — The Finale

One of Kilorn's mages, empowered by eolith, forces the citizens into open rebellion. At the same time, the rest of Kilorn's forces move against the resistance's civilian hideouts across the city, forcing the group to split up to protect them rather than staying together for the push on the palace. The soldiers attacking the hideouts act almost

possessed — unnervingly coordinated, relentless, wrong in a way nobody can name in the moment. The cause, unstated on the page: Alexander — secretly Apep in disguise — has been dosing Kilorn's forces' drinking water with eolith all along, giving him a direct line to manipulate them whenever it suits his purposes. This is what the "minor side experiments" in Acts Two and Three were actually for — weaker, diluted batches meant for mass dosing rather than combat strength, hiding in plain sight the whole time, with the water complaints and barrel arguments near Kilorn's base as the trail a re-reader can trace back through the whole book.

In the middle of this chaos, Hesiri is deliberately drawn away from the others. She's with Quen when it happens. Alexander lures her off alone, away from the main hideout, to the ruins of the old church — the same one from Book 1 where August once told her what really happened to her father. Nothing on the page needs to spell this out; the reader already knows the place, and so does Hesiri, the moment she realizes where she's ended up. Quen is ambushed in the same moment, cut off from Hesiri by several of Kilorn's destruction mages — with her fear of fire long gone by this point, the fight against them turns one-sided in her favor.

She attacks him there without knowing yet what he actually is. The fight is strange from the start — he's not fighting like a man defending himself, more like he's simply making sure she stays occupied. As it goes on he starts talking, mocking her in a way that doesn't track as ordinary taunting: fragments about chaos, about the function of the universe, the kind of thing that doesn't mean anything to Hesiri in the moment but reads very differently to a reader who's starting to suspect who "Alexander" really is. It's here that the truth becomes clearer and clearer without ever being confirmed outright.

Hesiri eventually realizes what's actually happening — that the fight itself is pointless, that he's not trying to win it, he's stalling her, keeping her away from wherever she's actually needed. The moment that lands, she's attacked by something else entirely: fast, dark, barely visible, tearing into the fight from outside it. She never gets a clear look at it — just an impression of speed and shape, something animal rather than human, gone again almost as soon as it hit her. She's knocked unconscious before she can process what it was, only able to register it afterward as some kind of creature in the dark. This is Apep's actual body, moving independently of whatever Alexander is doing at the same time — a detail left entirely unexplained on the page, planted for the reader to puzzle over rather than resolved here.

When Hesiri comes to, it's Quen who's woken her — having finished off the destruction mages and found her way back. There's something lying in the dirt beside them that wasn't there before: a single scale-shaped shard, black and glassy, with tiny points of light visible inside it, like looking into a clear night sky trapped in stone. Hesiri has no idea what it is, no memory of it appearing, and no time to think about it — she picks it up on instinct, more reflex than curiosity, and gets up to run straight back toward the fighting, Quen with her. It goes with her, unexplained, and stays unexplained for the rest of the book. She arrives in time to turn the tide at the main hideout, pushing back the soldiers attacking it and fighting alongside the rest of the group — Quen included — and Ladrien to finish clearing them out. Ladrien uses his touch-based illusion — the same ability that once fed Kilorn's paranoia and cruelty in earlier books — but only to put the attacking soldiers to sleep, nothing worse. It's a quiet, deliberate restraint worth noting: the ability that used to be a weapon aimed at breaking someone's mind is being used here to end a fight without killing anyone, a small but real sign of how far he's come from what it once made him do — and it's not lost on Quen, who's caught off guard by it, having never expected that particular kind of restraint from him.

By the time the hideout is secure, it's already too late for the bigger fight — Kilorn is already in the palace, using the purest eolith he's created to get the Neferit to let him through. The Inquisitor, badly weakened by the plague though still hunting Kilorn as his true priority, makes a final attempt to stop him and fails — ripped apart and beheaded by the Neferit guarding the palace grounds. This retroactively recontextualizes his death: he isn't simply outmatched by a Neferit outright, he's already compromised by the bite, which is why he finally falls here instead of earlier or never. The plague is the thing that makes this death make sense. Kilorn becomes the only person to enter the Emperor's palace since it was built.

In the aftermath, Hesiri is left with more questions than answers. She doesn't know what Alexander actually is — only that whatever attacked her in the ruins wasn't him, or wasn't only him, and neither adds up to anything she can explain to the others. When she goes looking for him afterward, wanting at least some answers, he's nowhere to be found — gone from the city entirely, as if he'd never been there at all.

The southern army — already marching since the man in heavy armor received the council's final order back in Act One — arrives at the city as it burns, ready to besiege it.

Aliserai 6: Emperor

by Leopold Ambry

In this outline: Act One · Opening State · The Sandstorm · Act Two · Inside the Palace — The Halls · Act Three · Inside the Palace — Kilorn · The Emperor vs. Apep (shown to the reader, not witnessed by the group) · The Bargain (Ladrien and Hesiri only) · Epilogue · Open Threads Deliberately Left for the Second Saga

Act One

Opening State

One month has passed since the fall of Iba'aresh. The resistance is in shambles, most of the church forces and the city guards dead. The southern army still waits outside the city, but hasn't moved to attack — its general is unwilling to force his way into the Emperor's domain, and nothing like what happened at the end of Book 5 has ever happened before; nobody knows what they'd actually be attacking into.

The city itself sits mostly empty in this stretch, survivors scattered or sheltering, no real authority left to hold it together. Hesiri, Nara, Elseth, Ladrien, and Quen spend this quiet month trying to work out how to get into the Emperor's palace at all.

Somewhere in this quiet month, Hesiri turns the shard over in her hands again — the one that was simply lying beside her when she woke in the ruins of the old church at the end of Book 5. She still has no idea what it actually is. It's clearly not ordinary stone: something about it feels charged, magical in a way she can't name or explain. What she has managed to establish, mostly out of restless curiosity during the wait, is that it's completely unbreakable — she's tried, and so has Elseth, whose gold can cut or cancel almost anything magical he's ever tested it against. It doesn't so much as scratch. Whatever it is, it isn't behaving like anything either of them has encountered before, and neither of them has an explanation for it by the time the month runs out.

A second, smaller question nags at her the same month, and gets no closer to an answer either: what happened to the rest of Kilorn's eolith. He was refining it in staggering quantities by the end of Book 5 — far more than what he used to buy his way past the Neferit — and none of it turned up anywhere in the wreckage of his operation once the dust settled. It should have been somewhere. It wasn't. She raises it once or twice during the month, gets nothing but shrugs, and eventually lets it drop under the weight of everything else there is to worry about. It's still unresolved, unmentioned again, when the sandstorm finally hits.

It's this stalled, waiting month that a sandstorm — a phenomenon that shouldn't exist in this world — finally breaks, engulfing the entire city and its surroundings and throwing everything into chaos. This is Apep's doing, though the group doesn't know that yet.

The Sandstorm

Apep, in his true purpose here, is clearing a path into the palace — the sandstorm and the wall of sand rising hundreds of meters into the air around the city are both his work. The storm tears apart the Neferit guarding the grounds as it passes, and once the sand settles, the entire city is buried. The group enters the palace through a tunnel carved through the sand — Apep's doing, though unstated to them at the time — hearing the muffled

cracking of Neferit metal somewhere deep in the sand around them as they walk in. Hesiri still has the shard on her, same as she's carried it the whole month. The instant they cross into the palace proper, it shifts in her grip, faint but unmistakable, like something in it stirred for half a second and went still again. She doesn't mention it. She isn't sure what there'd even be to say.

Act Two

Inside the Palace — The Halls

The interior is wrong in a way none of them can immediately name. Large, empty halls stretch out ahead, and there's no dust anywhere, no decay, nothing that reads as a place sealed away and forgotten. Torches are lit. Lamps and hanging lights burn steadily with no one to have lit them. Maps hang on the walls, current rather than ancient. Furniture sits in perfect, untouched condition, as if someone dusted and arranged it that morning. Every detail says someone lives here — and every hall they walk through says, just as clearly, that no one does. Both things are true at once, and it unsettles the group more than open hostility would.

The palace doesn't behave like a building the deeper they go. Halls that should dead-end open into more halls. Turns that should double back on themselves don't. The place is enormous on its own terms, but the group's sense of it stretching on past any reasonable size for a physical structure only grows the further in they push — less like a very large palace and more like something that stops being bound by ordinary space entirely past a certain point. Then the halls give way to things that shouldn't be inside a building at all: open fields under their own sky, forests with their own weather, what looks and feels like an actual ocean, waves and salt air and horizon, sealed somehow within walls that were visible from outside a few minutes before. None of it announces itself as illusion or dream — it simply is, exactly as real and physically present as the halls that led into it.

Throughout all of it, they feel like they're being watched — and they never are, not by anything they can find. No animals, no birds, no other person, servant, guard, or living thing anywhere in any of it, despite the overwhelming, constant sense of a presence just out of sight. It's the palace's single most disquieting quality: not danger, not an ambush waiting to happen, just the certainty of not being alone paired with total, unbroken solitude every time they actually look. Somewhere in this stretch, the shard comes up again — Hesiri mentions the way it moved at the threshold, and it gets turned over once more, same as it has been all month, without anyone landing on anything closer to an answer than "unbreakable and clearly magical" already gets them. It stays with her the rest of the way, an old unanswered question rather than anything they think to worry about.

One stretch of the journey opens onto a black sand desert, vast and silent, unlike anywhere else they pass through. Scattered across it in the distance are several colossal bodies, motionless, half-buried in the black sand — too large and too strange in shape to be anything the group recognizes, and none of them explained or approached closely enough to say what they actually are. Nothing here moves, nothing here is named. The group doesn't linger, but it's the one place in the entire palace that reads less like a wonder and more like a graveyard — left entirely unexplained, a visual the reader is meant to sit with rather than have answered.

This eventually leads them to Kilorn, waiting inside a vast golden forge. Canals of molten lava cut through the floor, feeding gigantic furnaces that heat raw gold into liquid around him. Heat radiates from every direction, thick enough to feel like its own kind of pressure. It's the first space in the whole approach that feels built for a

purpose rather than simply existing, and Kilorn is standing in the middle of it, waiting for them, like he already knew this was where they'd end up.

Act Three

Inside the Palace — Kilorn

Apep's parting gift to Kilorn: no longer fully human, needs no food or sleep, carries a genuine (small) sliver of divine, reality-warping power — enough to be a real threat to the group, though still a child compared to Apep or the Emperor.

Kilorn doesn't fully control this power — a month alone wasn't enough to master it, and it shows: effects occasionally land wrong or overshoot, and his precognition itself is fragmentary rather than reliable, flickering in and out rather than a clean, permanent sense of what's coming. That instability is *why* his foresight isn't consistent enough to save him outright — it's real, but partial and unmastered, same as the rest of what Apep gave him.

Kilorn's monologue (his final say on his philosophy, mid-fight): He believes the Emperor really did kill the gods and end the Age of Chaos — and that what followed wasn't peace, it was stagnation: one unaging ruler freezing the world in place instead of a warring pantheon. Nothing changes while the Emperor lives, and nobody's destiny is their own as long as that's true. He can't surpass or replace the Emperor — but he believes he's made himself the crack that let something powerful enough to hurt the Emperor into the palace. He knows he'll be remembered as a monster, not a liberator, and has made peace with that. Taunts the Emperor for never appearing or intervening, calling him "a thing, not a being" — and, almost as an aside, says the Emperor "isn't a god," just "a being that has no business being here." Never explained on the page (second-saga thread).

Bargain terms as Kilorn understood them: hold the group here, buy Apep time, keep the power permanently. He's unbothered about being used as Apep's entry point — sees it as the whole point. Visibly thrown when the group reveals the sandstorm was Apep's doing (not what he was told to expect) — first crack showing he wasn't told the real plan.

Fight opens with Kilorn immediately knocking the obsidian scale out of Hesiri's hand, sending it lost into the wreckage — clearly afraid of it specifically, never explained why on the page.

Elseth fights recklessly — grief/rage over Indira, whom he blames Kilorn for. The forge gives him more raw gold to work with than ever before, letting his power operate at full scale for the first time in the series (redirecting/hardening molten gold, reshaping the battlefield) — but it does nothing to Kilorn directly, same as it does nothing to Apep.

The forge itself takes real damage as the fight goes — furnaces crushed, canals rupturing and redirecting molten gold and lava into new paths — some of it just collateral, but some of it Elseth actively reshaping the terrain. This matters later: it's this same ongoing destruction/redirection of the forge's gold supply that sets up Elseth being able to sever the flow into it entirely once he's boosted.

The ambient gold saturating the room interferes with Hesiri, Nara, Ladrien, and Quen's powers (all weakened/unreliable) while empowering Elseth — an uneven fight where the person best suited to the room is the one whose power can't touch their actual opponent.

Key beat: Ladrien gives Elseth a stolen eolith crystal — one of several he secretly took from Kilorn's stockpile back in Book 5 (this is where it went). He deliberately doesn't offer it to Hesiri, Nara, or Quen. Elseth, driven by suppressed rage over Indira, takes it against his own principles. It works immediately: Elseth severs the gold flow into the forge, which also lifts the ambient interference on the other four, letting them fight at full strength for the rest of the battle. Ladrien secretly took his own dose earlier too — explains his stamina. Nobody but Ladrien and Elseth ever learns any of this happened.

Casualties, in order:

- Elseth — run through the hip by one of Kilorn's conjured weapons; survives but the wound never fully heals (seed of his permanent limp).
- Nara — Kilorn's precognition lets him anticipate her teleport; she loses her arm at the shoulder, goes down unconscious.
- Hesiri — Kilorn hurls molten gold; Quen shoves her mostly clear, but Hesiri still takes a burn/scar across the side of her face and loses the eye on that side — her first-ever visible, uncoverable injury.
- Quen — takes the rest of that same molten gold spray meant for Hesiri, burned badly across chest/front, out of the fight.

Ladrien can't touch Kilorn in a fight (illusions don't work on him) and spends the fight dragging the wounded clear instead — walks away physically untouched. While doing this, he's the one who stumbles on the lost scale in the wreckage.

The kill: With everyone else down, Ladrien throws a shaky, half-formed illusion that buys half a second of confusion (not because it fools Kilorn, just because it's strange). Hesiri uses that opening to activate her heart tattoo at full, uncontrolled force (fighting through the gold's interference) and drives the scale into Kilorn's forehead, killing him. Mid-strike she rips the gold off her skin — meaning she loses the ability to gauge depth and distance without her nape tattoo active. The only reason she can actually land the blow clean through Kilorn's guard is that activating the heart tattoo also brings the rest of her tattoos online, nape included — without that, blind on depth perception, she couldn't have closed the gap accurately. The activation cost — already established to shorten her life — is worse than usual because of the interference, and this is what starts her dying afterward.

Kilorn's death is final and unambiguous — he dies exactly as he intended, unrepentant.

The Emperor vs. Apep (shown to the reader, not witnessed by the group)

Cutaway scene, not witnessed by the group (they only feel tremors through the walls).

The Emperor, seen for the first time: white-haired, obsidian-skinned, golden mask, fights bare-handed, matches Apep blow for blow. Apep's true form: massive black serpent (visually matches the shard's obsidian surface — connection never stated on page). Emperor conjures orbs that damage Apep; Apep heals almost as fast — a war of attrition.

Apep taunts the Emperor mid-fight — implies the Emperor killed the gods and ended the Age of Chaos. Left deliberately ambiguous whether this is true or manipulation (thread for later).

Emperor conjures a golden sword that *does* hurt Apep (unlike Elseth's gold) — because it's an extension of the Emperor himself, not just gold. Worth being explicit about this distinction on the page.

Apep bites the Emperor's side; in the same motion the Emperor beheads him. Reads as a clean, final death to the reader — Apep's survival happens entirely off-page.

Emperor collapses, bleeding glowing red liquid (not normal blood) from two wounds — this is the chaos plague bite, the same affliction that killed the kemet Inquisitor, and a seed confirming colith = the Emperor's own blood (not stated explicitly, left for hindsight).

The Bargain (Ladrien and Hesiri only)

Kilorn is dead; Hesiri is convulsing from the tattoo's cost. Ladrien panics and runs off alone with her, deeper into the palace, leaving the others with Kilorn's body.

He prays into the dark, begging for help, telling her he loves her.

Apep answers — Ladrien recognizes him instantly (not a mystery to Ladrien, though the reader isn't told outright). Apep survived the Emperor off-page; how he finds Ladrien is also unexplained (second-saga thread). Apep needs Ladrien specifically because the Emperor holds power over the palace itself that bars Apep from leaving unhosted — he can't just walk out on his own; he needs a body to cross the threshold with, which is what makes this a real trade rather than Apep simply granting mercy.

The deal: Apep heals Hesiri in exchange for Ladrien being his host to cross the threshold out of the palace. Never shown being explicitly accepted on page — only the plea and Ladrien's reasoning (fully aware of who/what he's bargaining with, chooses it clear-eyed for her sake alone).

Meanwhile, the rest of the group is blinded by a sudden light and wakes up outside the palace among the collapsing sand — no memory of what happened to Ladrien/Hesiri. The light itself feels less like a rescue and more like being forcibly ejected — deliberately left unexplained, but meant to cast quiet doubt on Ladrien's later "grateful Emperor" story.

Epilogue

Group wakes up outside, not healed — Elseth barely conscious and still bleeding, Nara unconscious (arm gone), Quen unconscious (burned), Ladrien unhurt and carrying Hesiri, who's also unconscious. Resistance/Per Ankh survivors triage them on the spot. Nothing reverses what's already lost: Nara's arm stays gone, Elseth's hip never heals right (permanent limp), Quen's burns scar permanently.

Ladrien's lie, told to Hesiri alone when she wakes: Kilorn's death is true; for the rest, he tells her the Emperor won and revived her out of gratitude. He knows this is false and tells her anyway, to protect everyone from the truth of the Apep bargain. Quen wakes next and accepts the same story without pushing. Elseth wakes last and learns about his permanent limp only when he tries to stand.

Hesiri is largely unbothered by her own facial scar/lost eye — she's more focused on Nara, who is clearly downplaying the loss of her arm the same way Hesiri herself tends to minimize her own wounds. (Character-note beat, not plot-critical — can improvise in prose.)

Confirmed here: Apep survives and leaves via Ladrien as host, then departs entirely (nothing of him lingers in Ladrien). What Ladrien actually carries forward is the debt/knowledge of the bargain and the deliberate lie — not any possession by Apep. Emperor's post-bite condition is never addressed on the page (second-saga seed).

Time-skip beats: Sand recedes, council rebuilt, Kilorn's death is publicly read as the Emperor's clean victory (nobody knows the real story). Once Elseth's limp is permanent, Hesiri has a gold cane made for him — deliberate, quiet callback to what gold cost/meant in the forge. Neither of them discusses it explicitly.

Open Threads Deliberately Left for the Second Saga

Apep is not killed in Book 6 — he escapes the palace using Ladrien as the means to cross the threshold, then leaves entirely. He is not lingering inside Ladrien afterward, despite what the group believes happened to him.

What actually saved Hesiri is deliberately left ambiguous for the reader, though not for Ladrien — he knows it was Apep the moment it happens. The reader isn't told this here, only shown Ladrien's plea and the false account he builds afterward. What it means for Hesiri going forward, if anything, is a thread for the second saga.

The chaos plague bite on the Emperor is planted but not explored.

Ladrien's bargain and its true cost — not Apep's continued presence, but the debt, the fact that he knows exactly who saved Hesiri and chooses to lie about it anyway, and now a deliberate fabrication the whole group has accepted as history — are hidden from Hesiri and everyone else. That debt, and the lie built on top of it, is what comes due later.

Kilorn's full awareness of being used, and his indifference to it, leaves open just how much of his plan and ideology was ever actually dependent on Apep at all — a question the second saga can pick up when examining what Apep's influence on the empire's power structures really cost, versus what would have happened anyway.

Kilorn's fragments of precognition and his claim to now see "the whole picture" are left entirely unexplained — a hint that whatever Apep's power actually touches, it brushes up against something above even Apep and the Emperor, glimpsed here only through a dying man's half-understood claim rather than confirmed on the page.

Kilorn's offhand claim that the Emperor isn't a god — that he's "simply a being that has no business being here" — is dropped once, unexplained, and never picked back up in Book 6. Whether it means the Emperor comes from somewhere outside this world entirely, or something else Kilorn only half-understood himself, is a thread deliberately left for the second saga to answer.

Ladrien's theft of Kilorn's eolith at the end of Book 5, and his decision to use it himself and hand it to Elseth in the middle of this fight, is never addressed again after the fact — no confession, no reckoning, nothing that treats it as the significant line it actually is for either of them. Hesiri and Nara never learn it happened at all; Ladrien made that choice deliberately in the moment and nothing in the book's aftermath undoes it. It's another secret Ladrien is quietly carrying by the end of this book, on top of the bargain and the lie, and Elseth's own willingness to take it, driven by grief rather than conviction, is left sitting there too, unexamined — a private thing shared only between the two of them, invisible to everyone else in the group. What either of them actually thinks about having done it — and whether it changes anything about how they see themselves going forward — is left for the second saga.

The forceful, unpleasant nature of the light that expels the group from the palace is never explained or even remarked on within the book — but it sits in quiet tension with Ladrien's account of a grateful Emperor, and it's a thread worth paying off later: whatever the light actually was, "thanks" may not be the right word for it.

Kilorn's bargain with Apep was never what Kilorn thought it was. Apep never intended for him to survive the group at all — the "deal" giving him power to hold the door was never meant to be collected on. What Apep actually wanted was for Kilorn and the group to wear each other down or kill each other outright, clearing the field so he could make a fresh bargain afterward with whichever side was left standing, unencumbered by whatever promises he'd made to the side that lost. Kilorn's confusion about the storm in the fight itself is the first crack in this — evidence that he was never told the whole plan, or the true one, to begin with. This isn't revealed on the page in Book 6; it's confirmed later, in the second saga.

The obsidian shard Hesiri wakes up beside in the ruins at the end of Book 5 — the one she ultimately kills Kilorn with — is never explicitly identified as Apep's on the page. A reader who registers the visual match to Apep's true form later in the book can draw the connection themselves, but nothing in the text confirms it. Kilorn's own reaction to it — breaking from the fight the instant he sees it just to knock it out of her hand — is the strongest hint given that he knew exactly what it was and feared it, even though he never says so and the group only pieces it together by watching what he did rather than anything he tells them. That it's also completely unbreakable, resisting even Elseth's gold, is never explained either — left for the second saga along with everything else about what it actually is. What it means that Kilorn was killed with a piece of the very entity that made him what he'd become, and whether that detail carries any further significance, is left open as well.